

PLSC 197 / SODA 110N: Social Data, Technology, and Artificial Intelligence

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August 28, 2026

Generative AI

Generative AI begins with *models*:

- Trained on enormous amounts of existing text, images, audio, and code
- Learns the statistical patterns in that data (not facts, patterns)
- Given a prompt, it generates new content that plausibly continues those patterns
- It's prediction, not comprehension: useful, but not "thinking" the way a person does
- Examples for text: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, etc.

Generative AI models **generate stuff**.

Agentic AI relies on *agents*:

- Generative AI that can also act, not just respond
- E.g., use tools: search the web, run code, edit files, call other software
- Given a goal, it plans and executes multiple steps with less step-by-step human direction
- Generative AI pattern-completion engine is now wired into a loop of act → observe → act
- AI Studio lets you safely experiment with this

Agentic AI **generates stuff, then acts on it.**

Penn State's AI Studio

Link:

<https://aistudio.psu.edu/>

Description:

"AI Studio is Penn State's enterprise generative AI platform that provides access to leading AI models in one place. Whether you're exploring ideas, experimenting with AI workflows, or building something new, AI Studio makes it easy, safe, and flexible."



Available Models (8/27/2026)

What models are currently available in AI Studio?

Vendor	Model	Best Used For	Efficiency tier
OpenAI	GPT 5.6 Luna	General-purpose tasks, polished writing, detailed document review, coding, and more complex analysis and reasoning	🌱🌱
OpenAI	GPT 5.6 Terra	Complex analysis, multi-step reasoning, research-heavy tasks, advanced coding	🌱
OpenAI	GPT 5.4 Mini	Fast everyday tasks, concise writing, quick document review, lightweight coding, lower-complexity analysis	🌱🌱
Anthropic	Claude Sonnet 5	Long documents, detailed writing, policy review, summarization	🌱
Anthropic	Claude Haiku 4.5	Quick answers, short prompts, lightweight interactions	🌱🌱
Google	Gemini 3.6 Flash	Fast responses, chat-style questions, lower complexity tasks	🌱🌱
Google	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Research, structured analysis, advanced reasoning	🌱

...vs. free models:

OpenAI=Luna Anthropic=Sonnet 5 Google=Gemini Flash

Good things:

- It's free
- OpenChat = three models in one place
- Managed and supported by the University
- Allows (safe) agent creation
- “Operates in a protected environment”

PSU: “Do not use free personal AI accounts for Penn State - related teaching, learning, research, or work.”

Information Classification Levels

Level	Risk	Examples
One / Public	Low	Course Descriptions, Press Releases, Public Websites
Two / Internal	Moderate	Course Grades, Syllabi, Course Content
Three / Sensitive	High	SSN, Financial Aid Information, Driver's License Number
Four / Restricted	Critical	Controlled Unclassified Information, Payment Card Info

Example:

“Here are my professor’s lecture notes, the syllabus, and my feedback on the last three assignments. What am I doing wrong?”



Token Usage

Monthly Usage Limit

To make sure AI Studio is available for everyone in the University community, usage limits are in place. You can see your current usage at the top of your AI Studio window. How many tokens you use depends on the length and complexity of your questions and responses. Usage resets on the first day of each month.

If you have reached your current allocation, you may use the [AI Studio Monthly Usage Limit Increase Request form](#). Requests are evaluated on a case-by-case basis. To learn more about how to work within your usage limits, review [Best Practices for Using AI Tools](#).

In practice:

- Usage limits are generous
- Increasing usage limits is generally routine

In no particular order:

- AI Studio [general support page](#)
- [Best Practices for Using AI Tools](#)
- [“Getting Started with AI Studio”](#) (online course)
- [AI Studio Learning Path](#) (in CANVAS)
- [PSU Knowledge Base Articles](#) about AI Studio